

COOL STYLE The controversial fashion show in Gulmarg in Kashmir; Mar. 7

new campaign on the back of a private member bill moved by its Kupwara MLA Fayaz Ahmad Mir on February 10. It seeks a blanket ban on the sale and consumption of liquor in J&K.

"It is not a political but a social issue. The rising unemployment is pushing youth into drugs and alcohol. If Bihar, Gujarat and Nagaland can go dry, why not Kashmir," PDP leader Iltija Mufti had said during a signature campaign against alcohol in Srinagar in February. Mufti has been leading the Opposition charge against the ruling National Conference on this and other issues. Key opposition BJP, with 28 MLAs, is seen to be playing second fiddle.

Religious leaders joined the chorus against alcohol and have expressed outrage over the fashion show. The most prominent was the Valley's top cleric and head of the separatist faction of the Hurriyat Conference, Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, who has been resuming his activities since the restriction on his movements was lifted last year. "Already, lakhs of people are addicted to drugs. Yet they talk about economy and revenue when it comes to liquor ban.... If they can't benefit society, then at least for god sake, don't harm our values and morals," he responded when an NC legislator, Tanvir Sadiq, connected the sale of alcohol to tourism.

Kashmir, which lent its beauty to two generations of Bollywood films, had many cinemas and bars in its towns. The eruption of militancy in 1989 wiped off most. But, in recent years, J&K's liquor industry has been booming. Between 2022 and 2023, according to data from the excise department, 77 new liquor shops have come up—67 in Jammu and 10 in Kashmir. Overall, the number of liquor vends has increased by over 40 per cent, from 217 in 2021 to 305 in 2025—291 in Jammu and 14 in Kashmir. Revenue generated by the department from liquor has nearly doubled—from Rs 1,353 crore in 2020-21 to Rs 2,600 crore in 2024-25. The most consumed liquor remains the local JK Special Whisky, which is manufactured in the region's 22 distilleries.

The rise in revenue has also to do with the introduction of e-auctioning of liquor vends by the LG-led administration in 2021, ending the decades-old system of leases. This opened the space for new bidders and competitive bidding each year. "There's a huge interest in liquor bidding and, from this year, the solvency against the bidding amount (demonstrating a bidder's financial position) has been slashed from 100 per cent to 50 per cent," a J&K excise department official tells INDIA TODAY.

Earlier, before the bifurcation of Jammu & Kashmir, successive governments had scuttled legislature bills on prohibition. While the ruling NC in 1984 disapproved of a bill, the previous PDP-BJP government in 2016 ignored a widespread demand for prohibition in the assembly.

Significantly, a similar prohibition bill to that of the PDP was moved around the same time by the NC's Lal Chowk MLA, Ahsan Pardesi, as also one by an elected independent from Langate, Khursheed Ahmad Sheikh, the brother of jailed MP 'Engineer' Rashid.

Chief Minister Omar has chosen to be circumspect on the matter. "If we had to talk about it (the ban), we would have put it in our manifesto. Let the bill come, we will remind them (PDP) what they did in government," Omar told a digital media platform on February 27. J&K levies 50 per cent duty on liquor sales, and it forms a sizeable part of the cash-strapped UT's revenues. The Omar government cannot afford to lose it. ■

PROHIBITION PRESSURE ON OMAR

- **A fashion show in Gulmarg draws Kashmiris' ire, who deplore such an event during Ramzan**
- **This rekindles the continuing and old demand for a total ban on alcohol**
- **Three MLAs have moved bills in the assembly demanding prohibition**
- **But with excise duty from liquor making up a chunk of the cash-strapped UT's revenues, the ruling NC is in a bind**